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"ANYTHING'S POSSIBLE IN HUMAN NATURE," CHACKO TELLS HIS "FOUNTAIN-HAIRED NIECE", in Arundhati Roy's debut, *The God of Small Things*. "Love. Madness. Hope. Infinite joy." Roy's latest book, out in shops now, is a memoir built on the foundations of this insight, of this all-encompassing embrace of humanity, of humanness.

In *Mother Mary Comes to Me*, Roy presents her mother to us, not sublimated in fiction, but in her brutal, glorious entirety. "She's such an extraordinary, crazy, contentious person—woman—she needs to be shared with the world," Roy says in a Zoom call. "She belongs in the pages of literature, of history as 'she', not as a fictional character." A woman in full.

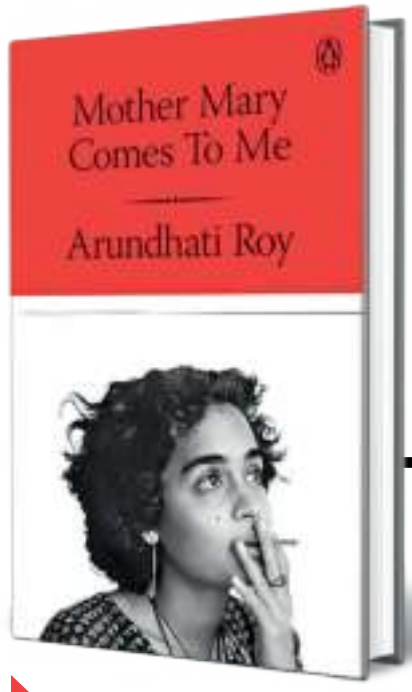
This is no hagiography. Roy doesn't soft-pedal her mother's terrifying violence—both physical and verbal—doesn't diminish the effect it has on her and her older brother, or hide her need to flee in the face of her mother's rage. But how could Mary Roy have been a 'conventional' Indian mother—that domestic goddess, that icon of self-abnegation and self-sacrifice—when her life was a long, loud denunciation of convention and its hypocrisies?

Mary Roy thrived, as few women do in India, as a public figure—the doyenne of a school she fashioned from rock and brush, and winner of a landmark lawsuit that gave Syrian Christian women the same rights as their male siblings to inherit property. Despite the upheaval, the havoc that marks Arundhati Roy's early life, this is not a book about a family being cleaved apart. Instead, everyone, however titanic their anger, finds room in their hearts and imaginations to reconcile, to learn to live with difference. When Roy is not quite three, her mother leaves her husband, a genial, charismatic alcoholic who manages a tea plantation in Assam, and takes the children to Ooty. There, in Roy's grandfather's house, largely abandoned except for an old English woman who seemed to be some sort of tenant, the three of them "lived like fugitives". An "Imperial Entomologist", Roy's grandfather's legacy is the violence he visits on and bequeaths to his family, and perhaps a streak of mad genius.

Not long after they move to Ooty, Mary Roy's mother and brother descend on the house to evict the squatters. Mary and the children were "running through the town in panic, trying to find a lawyer", a foreshadowing of more consequential legal battles later. Penniless and desperate, Mary eventually leaves Ooty. She heads to Kerala and Ayemenem, the village that is home to her mother and brother—a Rhodes scholar and Balliol man who had given up his previous life, including his Swedish wife and three children, to "start a pickle, jam and curry-powder factory".

For Mary, the move was a humiliation. "Life in Ayemenem," Roy writes in *Mother Mary Comes to Me*, "was like living on a ledge that we could be nudged off at any moment. Even Kochu Maria, the cook, would tell me that we had no right to be living there. She would mutter and grumble about the shamefulness of having fatherless children living under the same roof as decent people." Still, it is here that Mary starts her school. And it is here, that Roy herself experiences one of those Wordsworthian spots of time: a sensory experience so profound it nourishes her memory, her art, her very way of being throughout her life.

Without revealing very much about herself, Roy packs her mem-



MOTHER MARY COMES TO ME
By Arundhati Roy
PENGUIN HAMISH HAMILTON
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ROY'S INDOMITABILITY, HER ABILITY TO TURN ALMOST EVERY ADVERSITY INTO FAIRY TALE TRIUMPH, GIVES *MOTHER MARY COMES TO ME* A PICARESQUE QUALITY